AI & DEFENCE

War's New Rule Book

DRONES AND THE FUTURE OF WARFARE

The world is undergoing a paradigm shift in warfare. At the India Today conclave, three military experts argued that it is not AI alone, but a convergence of technologies like quantum computing, robotics and drone swarms that is redefining modern battlefields.

Lt Gen. Raj Shukla drew from recent conflicts to highlight how AI can process vast streams of data—from satellites to social media—and strike targets instantly. Sagar Defence founder Nikunj Parashar brought in the maritime dimension, emphasising that the strategic importance of sea control and sea denial is increasing, especially around critical choke points such as the Strait of Hormuz. Drone Foundation president Smit Shah pointed to the gap between capability and scale. While India has a strong base of skilled engineers and startups working on advanced drone technologies, the absence of consistent procurement pipelines is limiting growth, he said.

The consensus: India needs to accelerate AI integration, reforms procurement and build a robust defence-tech ecosystem at scale. ■

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **AI-driven decisions in war are crunching human response time from days to minutes**
- **India's bottleneck is scale, not skill. Lack of consistent procurement and policy is an obstacle**



ARUN KUMAR

NIKUNJ PARASHAR

Founder, Sagar Defence Engineering Pvt Ltd

Sea control and sea denial will define sovereignty in the maritime domain, especially at choke points like Strait of Hormuz

LT GEN. RAJ SHUKLA

Former General Officer Commanding-in-Chief, Army Training Command

Why can't we replicate AI-led frontiers along LOC and LAC? This tech is creating a new divide between strategic haves and have-nots

SMIT SHAH

President, Drone Federation India

Ordering many munitions for two years, then not at all for a long time, hinders the possibility of efficient production